The M Word

By Alan Ball

INTRODUCTION

ACTRESS: *The thought of quantifying and qualifying your relationship with your husband-or wife-to-be may sound ludicrous.*
ACTOR: *However, marriage is a formal agreement into which you are both entering. A vow is no different from a contract.*
ACTRESS: *And this venture is the most adventurous, daring and permanent of all.*
ACTOR: *By putting it into a business plan, couples are forced to agree upon certain terms and conditions, ways of handling issues and what happens when one does not fulfill his or her obligations.*
ACTRESS: *In one form or another, these things should be discussed by the time you decide to even discuss . . .*
TOGETHER: *The M Word by Alan Ball.*

A n office. A well-groomed Woman in a business suit sits at her desk, working furiously. Elsewhere in the office is a table or file cabinet on which sits a pitcher of water and two empty glasses. A Man in a business suit appears at the door, carrying a large, official-looking document and a personal notebook. He knocks to get her attention.

WOMAN: Yes?

MAN: Are you terribly busy? This won't take long. *(She puts her work aside and motions him to come in.)*

WOMAN: I can give you ten minutes. I have a very important presentation this afternoon.

MAN: Don't worry. I'm catching the three o'clock shuttle to D.C., which means I'll need to be out of here by - *(He performs some calculations on his wristwatch.)* - one forty-eight at the absolute latest.

WOMAN: I really admire a man who allocates his time efficiently.

MAN: I'll get right to the point. We've been working together for six months, three days, fourteen hours and _ *(Checks his watch again.)* - twenty-two seconds. During that time, I believe we have grown to

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enjoy each other's company -

WOMAN: I wouldn't necessarily say *enjoy* ...

MAN: Really.

WOMAN: It implies a level of passion we have yet to achieve.

MAN: Oh, well, of course. I didn't mean to paint this as an emotional thing.

WOMAN: I'm glad to hear you say that.

MAN: On the contrary, one of the things I value in our relationship is the complete lack of spontaneity, which virtually eliminates any element of surprise. I know in advance how you're going to react, and I'm able to plan my strategies accordingly.

WOMAN: And I can predict your strategies without fail, thus being able to manipulate you effortlessly, without your even knowing it. There is real security in that.

MAN: We have a lot to offer each other.

WOMAN: We keep each other on our toes.

MAN: Shall I mention the M word now?

WOMAN: Oh, no. Much too soon. You'd do better to keep the suspense going for a little while longer.

MAN: I admire your coaching skills. And I am secure enough in my masculinity not to be threatened by your criticism.

WOMAN: I appreciate that. *(Pause.)*

MAN: I need a woman to take to the Hamptons this summer. You're quite presentable in a bathing suit _

WOMAN: Thank you.

MAN: - and could arouse feelings of jealousy in other men with whom I compete for advancement in my social circle. One question: are you interested in producing offspring?

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WOMAN: My biological clock is ticking like mad.

MAN: Have you given any thought as to what qualities you seek in a potential procreative partner?

WOMAN: Any man who is straight, has a steady job and is not a mass murderer looks pretty good. Of course, these are preliminary projections. I would need to conduct a much more extensive study before actually undertaking such a challenging project.

MAN: Understood.

WOMAN: And yourself? What are your feelings on the issue?

MAN: Well, of course I want children.

WOMAN: Why?

MAN: Oh, many reasons. First, they're quite a prestige item these days.

WOMAN: Uh-huh.

MAN: Second, they would greatly reinforce my own and others' notions of my virility.

WOMAN: Uh-huh.

MAN: Third, I have many unresolved issues with my dead father that I could work out with a son of my own.

WOMAN: Uh-huh.

MAN: And fourth, I've always enjoyed pets.

WOMAN: What are your feelings on shared child-rearing duties?

MAN: Ah ... I'm open to the *concept.* I certainly plan to budget frequent parcels of quality time for the kids, but ... I guess I'm not sure what you mean exactly by shared child-rearing duties. Would you care to elaborate?

WOMAN: Will you agree to a quota system that ensures even distribution of diaper-changing responsibilities? Are you willing to begin networking

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immediately in order to improve a child's chances of getting into an Ivy League pre-school? Are you willing to undergo sensitivity training yourself in order to become a more nurturing parent and role model, thus alleviating some of the historical burden of which mothers carry a disproportionate share? *(Pause.)*

MAN: Can I think about that?

WOMAN: Of course, I don't think we have to come to any decision today.

MAN: Great. *(Checks his pad)* As far as economic considerations go, I am confident that our combined income would be formidable, and we can continue our futile attempt to fill the void in our lives with overpriced material goods.

WOMAN: That's all well and good, but I think that if we work together on this, using a mixture of jurisprudence and selective risk-taking, we should be able to make the leap from upwardly mobile to wealthy before we're forty-five.

MAN: Oh, I plan to become a millionaire before I'm forty.

WOMAN: Really. That doesn't give you much time.

MAN: I'm aware of that.

WOMAN: May I ask what your contingency plans are?

MAN: I'm considering several options, including suicide in the event of not achieving my goal.

WOMAN: An aggressive approach.

MAN: I work best when I'm under pressure.

WOMAN: Hmm. I would be forty myself at that time, still young enough to embark on a new life partnership. Trouble is, most of the men whom I would deem appropriate partners will be just beginning their mid-life crises, and will therefore be interested only in very young women who make

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them feel less anxiety about their own mortality. On the other hand, I could do a Cher thing, and take as a lover a man half my age, involved in some kind of manual labor. And preferably not too bright. Hmm. I doubt if such a thing would go over well here at work, but ... if you have a good life insurance policy I *could* stop working altogether. Maybe. Hmm. I'll need to think about this some more.

MAN: Of course.

WOMAN: By the way, have you planned your own mid-life crisis yet?

MAN: Not fully, but I have settled on a basic approach.

WOMAN: Would you mind briefing me on it?

MAN: Not at all. *(Flips through pages.)* My target age is fifty, give or take a few years. I plan to start small, an expensive foreign sports car, some flashy clothes, a harmless infatuation with a much younger woman, not acted upon

WOMAN: Such restraint. I'm impressed.

MAN: Well, you might want to withhold judgment, because then I thought I would move up to a serious affair of frightening intensity with an emotionally disturbed model or actress, leading to a temporary separation from my wife and family, several humiliating social episodes, some random drunkenness and maybe even a brief drug problem, all culminating in a life-or-death struggle for my very soul.

WOMAN: That's awfully dramatic.

MAN: I believe at that point, having worked as hard as I plan to, I will deserve it.

WOMAN: I could score some major sympathy points, as well as impressing others with my ability to hold up under such a scandal. My dignity index would soar.

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MAN: Both men and women will look down upon me but secretly admire my impetuous and adventurous nature. Of course, if everything goes according to plan, I will realize the folly of my ways, and return to you with a new level of maturity, humility and respect for all that you offer me.

WOMAN: I, of course, will have suffered tremendously, and through your guilt will be able to get whatever I want from you until you die.

MAN: Naturally.

WOMAN: It's an attractive scenario ... but I'm worried about the effect it might have on the children.

MAN: Negligible. They should be hopelessly neurotic by that point, anyway.

WOMAN: You think?

MAN: Definitely. After years of private school, under constant pressure to succeed? They will be addicted to overachievement and equipped with completely unrealistic standards and unattainable goals.

WOMAN: Just like us!

MAN: Ulcers before they finish adolescence, you mark my words.

WOMAN: You're certainly optimistic.

MAN: You have to think big.

WOMAN: I must admit, I find your enthusiasm contagious.

MAN: Then shall I bring up the M word?

WOMAN: I think you may proceed.

MAN: Well. I propose that you and I consider getting mar - *(He is unable to say it.)* Excuse me. I must have something in my throat. *(Indicating water.)* May I? *(He pours himself a glass of water and drinks.)* Let's try that again. I propose that you and I get mar - *(Again, he is unable to say it.)* Excuse me. *(He steps aside, and goes through some sort of athletic*

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warm-up ritual.) I am stronger than I've ever been and getting stronger every day. I am stronger than I've ever been and getting stronger every day. I am stronger than I've ever been and getting stronger every day. *(Some intense breathing.)* I can do this. I am capable of this. I can argue persuasively, I can drive my point home, I can sell anything to anybody. *(He takes a deep breath and the faces the Woman, who has resumed working.)* I'm ready now.

WOMAN: Oh. *(She puts her work down and looks at him.)*

MAN: I propose that we get mar - *(Again, he is unable to say it.)* Damn. *(He pours another glass of water and douses his face with it. Blurting.)* Would you like to merge? *(Pause.)*

WOMAN: I would consider it.

MAN: Great. *(Handing her the document he entered with.)* I've taken the liberty of drawing up a preliminary proposal, outlining some of the things we've talked about. I'd like for you to read it, at your convenience, and then get back to me with your feedback.

WOMAN: May I make notes on this?

MAN: Of course, it's just a draft, and I have several copies. Oh, my god. *(Grabs his notebook.)* Well, I hate to make a presentation and run, but I should have left thirty seconds ago. I'm really looking forward to hearing your comments on the proposal. May I call you on Monday?

WOMAN: Please do.

MAN: Okay! *(He leaves. The Woman waits until he's out of earshot. She then performs a brief, frantic, savage dance of joy before returning to her work.)*

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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